THE BATTLE OF CAPE ECNOMUS

By 256 BCE the Roman Republic had been fighting Carthage for control of Sicily for eight years. Increasingly confident of their power to challenge Carthaginian dominance at sea, the Romans decided to mount an invasion of North Africa, sailing across the Mediterranean from Sicily to put Carthage itself under threat. They assembled a vast fleet which, according to the historian Polybius, numbered 330 ships. Most were quinqueremes with around 100 rowers. For the invasion attempt each ship also carried about 150 soldiers. The Roman consuls Lucius Manlius Vulso and Marcus Atilius Regulus led the expedition. The Carthaginians were well aware of Roman plans and determined to stop the invasion taking place. They assembled a fleet of broadly similar size, also in Sicily at Heraclea Minoa, under the command of the generals Hanno and Hamilcar. The scene was set for one of the largest battles in the entire history of naval warfare.

HAMILCAR'S STRATAGEM

As the Roman fleet set out for Africa, the Carthaginians spread theirs out in a line across its path, with its left wing close to the Sicilian shore. Hamilcar was in the center and Hanno on the right. The Romans advanced in a compact formation. In the van were two squadrons, each commanded by a consul. Behind these a third squadron towed horse transports. A fourth squadron protected the rear. Assuming that the Romans would attempt simply to smash through the Carthaginian line, Hamilcar ordered his captains in the center to withdraw as the Romans approached. This would draw the Roman van forward, allowing the Carthaginian wings to outflank them.



Frieze of a Roman warship
Despite the success of the corvus against the Carthaginians, it was subsequently abandoned in favor of a tower for launching missiles.

At first Hamilcar's plan worked. The leading Roman squadrons surged forward and a gap opened up between them and the rest of the fleet to the rear. At a signal from Hamilcar, the ships in the Carthaginian center turned back to face the Roman quinqueremes. The ships on the left turned inward to engage the Roman third squadron, whose warships were forced to cast the transports adrift in order to defend themselves. Meanwhile Hanno's right wing, with the Carthaginians' fastest ships, fell fiercely upon the fourth squadron in the rear.

Both sides sought to exploit their strengths. The Romans had the better soldiers and, in the spiked corvus, a superbly effective method of grappling and boarding an enemy ship. The Carthaginians, as the more skilled sailors, hoped to outmaneuver the Romans. Their aim was to avoid being boarded and to sink ships by ramming them from the side or rear.

CRUCIAL TURNING POINT

Hamilcar's plan fell apart in the center, where the two Roman squadrons had the advantage. The Carthaginian galleys found it difficult to manoeuvre in a dense mêlée. A number of them were captured—a corvus spike smashed into their deck and Roman legionaries swarming across to board—and the rest fled. Vulso secured the captured vessels while Regulus led a force of quinqueremes back to aid the rear squadron. This had suffered serious losses, but the arrival of Regulus's ships drove Hanno off. The Roman third squadron, hemmed in against the shore, had adopted a defensive formation with their prows facing outward, holding off the Carthaginians, who thus found themselves trapped as both Vulso and Regulus came up behind them. The Romans succeeded in capturing 50 Carthaginian ships.

The Roman fleet was in no condition to pursue the scattered Carthaginian survivors and retired to Sicily for a refit before proceeding with the planned invasion of North Africa. After some initial success, the invasion itself resulted in disaster, but from this point on the Carthaginians could never again hope to achieve dominance at sea.

THE FIRST PUNIC WAR



THE BATTLE OF CAPE ECNOMUS

Date	256 BCE
Location	Off Cape Ecnomus, Sicily
Result	Roman victory

COMBATANTS

ROMAN REPUBLIC	CARTHAGE

COMMANDERS

Lucius Manlius Vulso **Marcus Atilius Regulus**	**Hamilcar Barca** **Hanno**

FORCES

Ships: 330 **Men:** 139,000	**Ships:** 350 **Men:** 147,000

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** 24 ships sunk	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 64 ships captured, 30 ships sunk

3 THE CENTER COLLAPSES
In the center the Roman ships make highly effective use of the corvus to board and capture enemy ships. As the remaining Carthaginians flee, the victorious Romans are now free to go to the aid of the beleaguered squadrons in the rear.

